A POOR GIRL HELPED A BILLIONAIRE CEO GRANDPA WALK AGAIN

A feature-length drama

Written by
[WRITER'S NAME]

Mary's AI Movies

Running time: 60 minutes

CHARACTERS

IRETI ALADE (23). The heroine.

CHIEF BABATUNDE ADENUGA (75). The billionaire grandpa.

FEMI ADENUGA (33). The billionaire CEO grandson.

GABRIEL OKAFOR (33). Femi's best friend and Group Head of People.

MAMA FUNMI ALADE (48). Ireti's mother.

DAYO ALADE (17). Ireti's little brother.

AUNTY RONKE (52). The head housekeeper.

MALLAM AUDU (62). The gateman.

DR. HASSAN BELLO (50). Chief's orthopaedic doctor.

MR. LEKAN BAMIDELE (58). Group Vice-Chairman.

NURSE GRACE (30). The caretaker Chief pushes away in the cold open. Navy scrubs.

DR. OKORO (55). The public-hospital doctor treating Mama Funmi. Tired and kind, in a faded white coat.

MR. JIDE (45). Manager of Bukka Royale. A sweaty, loud man in a polo shirt.

CHIOMA (24). A waitress at Bukka Royale. She's sharp-tongued and chews gum.

SEGUN ADENUGA (52). Chief's eldest son and Femi's father, an oil-and-gas executive in Abuja.

KUNLE ADENUGA (48). Chief's second son, a banker in Port Harcourt.

LOLA ADENUGA-WRIGHT (45). Chief's daughter, who lives in London.

COMMANDER KOLA AJALA (72). A legendary juju musician, *fictional*, in a white suit with a gold guitar.

KEHINDE ALADE Ireti's late father, seen only in photographs. Danfo driver, broad smile, a burn scar across his right palm.

1 INT. ADENUGA MANSION, BANANA ISLAND — CHIEF'S BEDROOM AND GRAND STAIRCASE — DUSK 1

A slow aerial shot over the Lagos lagoon at dusk, with storm clouds rolling in. A white mansion sits on the water's edge with every curtain closed. Thunder rumbles.

SUPER: "A POOR GIRL HELPED A BILLIONAIRE CEO GRANDPA WALK AGAIN"

SUPER: "Written by [WRITER'S NAME]"

Inside, a huge bedroom. On a silver tray sits a small birthday cake with one unlit candle and a card: "HAPPY 75TH, DADDY — FROM ALL OF US." It's untouched. CHIEF BABATUNDE ADENUGA stands at the window in a white kaftan, leaning on an ivory-handled cane, holding a phone on video call. On screen is SEGUN, in a busy Abuja office, adjusting his tie.

SEGUN
Happy birthday, Daddy! Did the wine arrive? I sent the expensive one.

CHIEF
The wine arrived.
(beat)
My son did not.

SEGUN
(laughing it off)
Daddy, please, not today.

CHIEF
When are you bringing the twins? I last saw them when they were seven. They're twelve now. I know them from photographs, Segun. Like strangers in a newspaper.

SEGUN
It's a bad month. The merger, the Senate committee…

CHIEF
Every month is a bad month.

SEGUN
(glancing off-screen; someone is calling him)
Christmas. I promise. We'll all come at Christmas.

CHIEF
You promised last Christmas.

SEGUN
Daddy, they're calling me in. I love you. Bye-bye!

The screen freezes, then: "CALL ENDED — 1:12". Chief stares at it. His jaw tightens. His hand shakes. Then he hurls the phone onto the marble floor, and glass sprays everywhere.

NURSE GRACE rushes in, in navy scrubs.

GRACE
Sir! Sir, is everything okay?

CHIEF
(not looking at her)
Leave my room.

GRACE
Sir, your blood pressure. Please, let me help you to the chair…
(she gently takes his elbow)

CHIEF
(shoving her hard; she stumbles into the dresser)
Don't touch me! Why are you here? Mm? Because I pay you! Everybody in this house is paid to smile at me. My children too. Paid with my money to forget me!
(pointing his cane at her)
Go home to your own father, if he's still alive, and see whether you'll even visit him.

Silence. Grace straightens up slowly with tears in her eyes.

GRACE
(quietly)
My father is dead, sir.

Chief's face flickers with shame. He opens his mouth, but no apology comes out. Grace unpins her name badge, places it on the dresser and walks out.

AUNTY RONKE appears in the doorway with a silver tray: a glass of water and one small BLUE TABLET.

RONKE
Your evening tablet, sir. You've been shouting. It's for your pressure.

Chief swallows it without looking. Ronke watches him swallow, a beat too long. Then she closes the door slowly.

Chief stands alone, breathing hard. He looks at Grace's name badge. His face softens. He limps out onto the landing with his cane.

CHIEF
(calling down the stairs, almost gentle)
Grace… Grace, come back. I didn't mean…

He reaches the top of the grand curved staircase, 22 marble steps. His POV starts to BLUR. The chandelier swims. The steps tilt.

CHIEF
(blinking hard)
Grace…?

His cane slips on the marble. In slow motion he falls, tumbling down the staircase. The cane clatters down after him. He lands at the very bottom beneath the giant oil portrait of his late wife, MAMA ABIKE, smiling in gold gele.

Silence, except the rain. Chief lies still. His fingers twitch, reaching weakly toward the portrait. Upstairs, a door opens a crack, and we see half of Aunty Ronke's face looking down. She doesn't scream. She doesn't run. She waits.

FADE TO BLACK.

2 INT. PRIVATE HOSPITAL, IKOYI — VIP SUITE — NIGHT 2

A gleaming private hospital at night, with an ambulance's blue light flashing in the rain at the entrance.

Chief lies unconscious in a bed with tubes and a monitor beeping. FEMI ADENUGA bursts in, tie loose and two phones in his hand. GABRIEL is right behind him. DR. HASSAN BELLO holds up an X-ray.

FEMI
Doctor, talk to me. How bad?

DR. HASSAN
He fractured his hip and the fall bruised his lower spine.
(He points at the X-ray.)
There's severe swelling around the nerves. Mr. Adenuga, I'll be honest with you. From what I see tonight, your grandfather will not walk again.

Femi's phones slowly go quiet in his hands.

FEMI
There must be something. Germany. America. I'll fly in any specialist…

DR. HASSAN
You can fly him anywhere in the world, but the spine doesn't read passports. He'll need a wheelchair, full-time care and physiotherapy to keep him comfortable. We'll repeat the scans when the swelling goes down. Until then… prepare him.

Chief's eyes open slowly. He has heard everything. Femi sits on the bed and takes his grandfather's hand in both of his.

FEMI
Grandpa. I'm here. Everything will be fine. I promise you.

Chief looks at the hand holding his. Then, slowly and deliberately, he turns his face away to the wall. Femi is left holding a hand that doesn't hold back.

The door opens. MR. LEKAN BAMIDELE enters in a black agbada with a giant bouquet of white lilies.

LEKAN
Chief! Ah! God forbid bad thing!
(He puts the flowers down and pats Chief's blanket.)
Rest, Chief. Rest. Femi and I will carry the company. You don't need to worry about anything. Anything at all.

In the corner, holding Chief's overnight bag, stands AUNTY RONKE. Lekan's eyes meet hers. The smallest nod passes between them, and nobody else sees it.

In the corridor, Femi is on the phone, pacing.

FEMI
Dad, he fell down twenty-two steps.
(beat)
No, the doctor says he can't walk.
(beat)
You're not coming?

SEGUN (V.O., ON THE PHONE)
Hire the best caretaker in Lagos, Femi. Pay anything. Money is not the problem.

Femi lowers the phone.

FEMI
(to Gabriel, bitter)
Money is the only thing in this family that's never the problem.

Gabriel puts a hand on his shoulder. Through the glass, Chief stares at the wall.

FADE TO:

3 INT. PUBLIC HOSPITAL, IKEJA — FEMALE WARD — DAY 3

A crowded public hospital: a peeling green sign, women waiting on benches, a ceiling fan turning slowly in a long ward of twelve beds.

MAMA FUNMI lies in the last bed, thin and smiling. IRETI sits beside her in a faded yellow blouse, braiding her mother's hair. DAYO sits on the floor reading a JAMB past-question book.

DAYO
Sister, what's the past tense of "seek"?

IRETI
Sought.

DAYO
And the past tense of "money"?

IRETI
"Finished."
(Mama Funmi laughs, then coughs. Ireti's smile drops.)
Dayo, go and buy pure water. Two sachets. Take this.
(She gives him a crumpled ₦100 note.)

DAYO
(standing)
Two sachets of water for a hundred naira. This country.

Dayo leaves. Ireti takes her mother's hand and hums an old Yoruba lullaby. Mama Funmi closes her eyes.

DR. OKORO appears in the doorway with a brown file.

DR. OKORO
Miss Alade. Can I talk to you?

In the corridor, he closes the file before he speaks. That's how she knows.

DR. OKORO
The growth on your mother's heart is bigger than we thought. It's

pressing on the valve. Without surgery…

(beat)

I'd give her one year. Maybe less.

Ireti's hand goes to the wall to steady herself.

IRETI

One year.

DR. OKORO

There's a hospital in Chennai, in India, that does this operation every week. Very good results. We can book it, the surgery, the flight, everything. But it costs about thirty-eight million naira.

IRETI

(a small, broken laugh)

Thirty-eight million.

DR. OKORO

I'm sorry, my dear. There's nothing more we can do for her here.

He touches her shoulder and walks away. Ireti slides down the wall onto the floor and bursts into tears, covering her mouth so the ward won't hear.

Back inside, she wipes her face hard and fixes on a smile. Mama Funmi opens her eyes.

MAMA FUNMI

Why are you crying?

IRETI

I'm not crying, Mummy. Dust.

MAMA FUNMI

(quietly)

Since when does dust enter a hospital?

IRETI

(fluffing her pillow)

This hospital? Everything enters this hospital. Even goats.

Mama Funmi laughs. Ireti laughs with her, and behind her mother's head, her face crumples.

That night, alone on a hospital bench, Ireti writes in a small notebook:

SUPER: ""Surgery: ₦38,000,000. My salary: ₦40,000 a month. = 79 years.""

She stares at it, then underlines: "Mummy has ONE."

FADE TO:

4 INT. BUKKA ROYALE RESTAURANT, IKEJA — DAY 4

A busy Lagos street: danfo buses, a hawker selling gala, smoke rising from a roadside grill. A painted sign reads "BUKKA ROYALE: AMALA • EBA • POUNDED YAM".

Ireti carries four plates on one arm. MR. JIDE, the manager, waves her over to the counter.

MR. JIDE
Ireti! You broke a plate on Monday. Two thousand naira. From your salary.

IRETI
Sir, the plate was already cracked. Chioma dropped it…

MR. JIDE
Did Chioma's name appear on the plate?
(He laughs at his own joke.)

IRETI
Sir, please. I need an advance on next month's salary. My mother…

MR. JIDE
Advance? Ah-ah. Am I a bank? Forty thousand. End of month. Like everybody.

CHIOMA leans on the counter, chewing gum.

CHIOMA
Ireti and her "my mother." Everybody has a mother.

Ireti's phone buzzes: "DAYO".

DAYO (V.O.)
Sister, JAMB registration closes on Friday. Form and lesson together, twenty-five thousand.

IRETI
(eyes closed)
I'll find it.

DAYO (V.O.)
You said that last week.

IRETI
And I'm saying it again this week. Go and read.

That evening, on a packed danfo bus, Ireti counts the money in her purse: ₦3,200. Through the window she sees a giant billboard: CHIEF BABATUNDE ADENUGA, smiling in a suit, "ADENUGA CREST GROUP — BUILDING NIGERIA SINCE 1979." The bus passes it. She keeps looking back at his face.

FADE TO:

5 INT. THE ALADE HOME, MUSHIN — EVENING 5

A face-me-I-face-you compound at dusk: children playing barefoot, a woman frying puff-puff, a generator roaring.

Ireti pushes the door open, exhausted, and stops. Mama Funmi, discharged and wrapped in a shawl, is at the kerosene stove stirring a pot of jollof rice. Fried fish sizzles beside it.

IRETI
Ah! Mummy! What are you doing? You're supposed to be resting!

DAYO
(mouth full)
Sister, sit down and taste it first. This food is SWEET.

IRETI
(not sitting)
Where did the money for fish come from?

Mama Funmi and Dayo exchange a look.

DAYO
(proudly)
Me. I help people in my class fill their workbooks. Five hundred naira per book. I did twelve this week.

IRETI
(sharp)
You did WHAT?

DAYO
It's just homework…

IRETI
Don't ever do that again! Do you hear me? You're writing JAMB in two months. Read YOUR books! Not other people's!

DAYO
(standing, hurt)
Sister, I see how you're struggling. You walk home to save transport. You eat once a day. You think I'm blind?

IRETI
It's my responsibility, Dayo. Not yours.

DAYO
(quietly)
No problem.

MAMA FUNMI
Ireti. Why are you shouting? At least thank your brother. He brought food into this house.

IRETI
(turning to her mother)
Mummy, you know what the doctor said. You're not supposed to be standing at a hot stove!

MAMA FUNMI
(calm, still stirring)
I know what the doctor said. That's exactly why I'm cooking.
(beat)
I'm trying to make the best of the time I have with you and your brother.

The room goes very still. Dayo lowers his plate.

DAYO
Mummy… what do you mean, "the time you have"?

MAMA FUNMI
(too quickly)
Nothing. Ireti, go and bathe. Then come and join us. The rice is getting cold.

Ireti looks at her mother. Her mother holds her gaze and gently shakes her head: not in front of him.

Later, all three sit on the mat eating. On the small TV, the news:

NEWSREADER (V.O.)
…billionaire industrialist Chief Babatunde Adenuga, seventy-five, founder of Adenuga Crest Group, is reported to be in a wheelchair after a fall at his Banana Island home. Doctors say he may never walk again…

An advert follows: Chief's mansion, private jets, a gold tower.

DAYO
(open-mouthed)
Mummy, look! Look at this man's house! This man is rich o!

MAMA FUNMI
He's very, very rich.
(beat)
And money can't buy legs.

IRETI
(watching Chief's photo on screen)
He looks sad. Even in the advert, smiling, his eyes are sad.

DAYO
Sister, with that money, I'd be sad in a jet.

They laugh, all three of them, for the first time tonight.

Night. Everyone is asleep. Ireti sits outside on an upturned bucket under the compound's single bulb, crying silently into her wrapper. Inside, her mother's voice comes softly.

MAMA FUNMI (O.S.)
Ireti. Come.

FADE TO:

6 INT. THE ALADE HOME — NIGHT 6

The dark room lit by one candle. Dayo snores on the mat. A small framed photo hangs on the wall: KEHINDE ALADE, smiling, in a danfo driver's green shirt, his right palm scarred.

Ireti kneels beside her mother's mattress.

MAMA FUNMI
(whispering)
I heard the doctor. Hospital walls are thin.

IRETI
Mummy…

MAMA FUNMI
I know I'm dying. I'm not afraid.
(She takes Ireti's face in her hands.)
When I go, take care of your brother. Make sure he finishes school. Promise me.

IRETI
No.

MAMA FUNMI
Ireti…

IRETI
No, Mummy. I'll find a way.

MAMA FUNMI
How? Thirty-eight million? We don't even have thirty-eight thousand.

IRETI
(firm, tears falling)
I'll find a way. I don't know how. But I'll find a way.

Mama Funmi looks up at her husband's photo and smiles faintly.

MAMA FUNMI
You sound like your father. Do you remember what he used to say?

IRETI
(a wet laugh)
"When the fire is high, somebody has to put their hand in."

MAMA FUNMI
He put his hand in a fire once. For a stranger. That's how he got that scar.
(She yawns, drifting off.)
I'll tell you that story one day…

IRETI
Tell me now.

But her mother is asleep.

Ireti looks up at the photo of her father and his scarred palm. She presses her own palm flat against the glass.

IRETI
(whispering)
Daddy. Show me the fire.

FADE TO:

7 INT. BUKKA ROYALE — LUNCHTIME RUSH — DAY 7

The restaurant is packed: steam rising from pots of ewedu and gbegiri, a radio playing fuji, and plastic chairs scraping.

GABRIEL OKAFOR walks in in a grey suit, on a phone call, and sits at a corner table. CHIOMA goes over, chewing gum.

GABRIEL
(on the phone)
…no, tell the board three o'clock, not two…
(covering the phone, to Chioma)
Amala, please, with ewedu. Assorted. Five meats.
(back to the phone)
…no, not you, I'm ordering food…

Chioma brings a steaming plate: EBA with ewedu and five meats. Gabriel ends his call and looks down.

GABRIEL
Sorry, madam. I asked for amala.

CHIOMA
You said eba.

GABRIEL
(polite)
I said amala. I was on the phone, maybe it wasn't clear. Please, just change it for me.

CHIOMA
(hand on hip)
Oga, once food is served, it's sold. I can't change it. My madam will kill me.

GABRIEL
I'll pay for both. It's not about…

CHIOMA
It's not my problem!
(She hisses and storms off into the kitchen.)

Gabriel sighs and looks at the plate. Ireti, across the room, has seen everything. She walks over.

IRETI
Good afternoon, sir. I'm so sorry for my colleague's attitude. Please give me one minute.

She takes the plate into the kitchen. Through the hatch, we see her talking to the cook, then digging into her apron pocket and paying the difference from her own ₦3,200. She comes back with a perfect plate of AMALA, ewedu, gbegiri and five meats.

IRETI
Amala, sir. With extra gbegiri. On the house.

GABRIEL
(touched)
On the house? Did your manager approve that?

IRETI
(smiling)
My manager doesn't know. Let's keep it that way.

GABRIEL
(laughing)
Thank you. Truly. What's your name?

IRETI
Ireti, sir.

GABRIEL
Ireti. "Hope."
(He studies her.)
You speak beautifully. Where did you school? Aren't you too young to be working in a restaurant?

IRETI
I was studying Nursing, sir. 300 level. My father died, and the

school fees died with him.
(She shrugs with a small smile.)
Now I nurse plates.

GABRIEL
(quiet, impressed)
Nursing.
(He thinks, then takes out a gold-edged card and writes something on the back.)
Come to this address tomorrow, 8 a.m. Tell them Gabriel sent you.

IRETI
(reading the card)
Sir… what is it for?

GABRIEL
A job nobody can keep.
(He stands and leaves a big tip.)
Something tells me you might.

Gabriel leaves. Mr. Jide snatches the card out of Ireti's hand and reads it.

MR. JIDE
Adenuga Crest Tower?
(laughing)
You?
(He flicks the card back at her.)
If you go for any interview tomorrow, don't bother coming back here.

Ireti picks the card up off the floor and wipes it clean on her apron.

FADE TO:

8 EXT./INT. ADENUGA CREST TOWER, VICTORIA ISLAND — MORNING 8

A 40-floor glass tower, its gold "AC" logo shining in the sun. A queue of a THOUSAND people snakes around the block: nurses in white, graduates in suits, people holding certificate folders.

Ireti joins the end of the queue in her faded yellow blouse and taped slippers. A woman in a sharp suit looks her up and down.

WOMAN IN QUEUE
Is this the cleaners' line?

IRETI
(politely)
I don't know, ma. Is it?

Laughter around her. At the gate, a SECURITY MAN blocks her.

SECURITY MAN
Where's your CV? Your certificates?

IRETI
(holding out the gold card)
Gabriel Okafor sent me.

The security man reads the card. His face changes: "GROUP HEAD OF PEOPLE". He lets her through, still confused.

INT. HALL. A three-person panel at a long table. Ireti sits in a chair that's too big for her.

PANELIST
Caretaker to Chief Babatunde Adenuga. Twelve caretakers in four months. One lasted two days. Why should we give YOU this job?

IRETI
(after a moment)
Because I won't leave.

The panel laughs together.

PANELIST
That's what all twelve of them said.

IRETI
Then maybe they had somewhere else to go, ma.
(beat)
I don't.

The laughter stops.

Outside, Ireti walks home along the long expressway in the afternoon heat to save transport money, slippers in her hand. She looks back once at the gold tower and shakes her head at her own foolishness.

FADE TO:

9 INT. FIVE-STAR RESTAURANT, IKOYI — DAY 9

A rooftop restaurant with white tablecloths, the lagoon below and a waiter pouring sparkling water.

FEMI and GABRIEL eat lunch. Femi isn't eating. A thick folder of CVs sits beside his plate.

FEMI
He's not himself, Gabe. He sits in that dark room staring at the phone, waiting for my father to call. When the phone rings and it's not family, he throws it.
(He rubs his eyes.)
Twelve caretakers. He made a nurse with twenty years' experience cry on day one.

GABRIEL
And the shortlist?

FEMI
(slapping the folder)
Three hundred nurses. Certificates from London, Canada, everywhere. They'll all quit by Friday.

GABRIEL
I know someone.

FEMI
Who?

GABRIEL
A waitress. Ireti. She served me yesterday. Her colleague insulted me, and she fixed it, paid for it from her own pocket, and smiled like it cost nothing. She studied Nursing before her father died.

FEMI
(unimpressed)
Gabe. Being nice in a restaurant doesn't mean she'll survive my grandfather.

GABRIEL
Femi. I hire people for a living. I know a good girl when I see one.
(beat)
And she said something to the panel. "Maybe the others had somewhere else to go. I don't."

Femi is quiet for a moment. His phone buzzes: "LEKAN BAMIDELE". He answers.

LEKAN (V.O.)
Femi, my son. The board is worried. If Chief is… incapacitated… the AGM in six months must discuss the chairmanship. His shares. Just procedure.

FEMI
He's not incapacitated, Uncle Lekan. He's injured.

LEKAN (V.O.)
Of course, of course. Procedure.

Femi hangs up, troubled. He slides the folder away.

FEMI
Fine. Hire the waitress.

Femi looks out over the lagoon toward Banana Island, where his grandfather's mansion sits with every curtain closed. Gabriel quietly texts on his phone.

FADE TO:

10 INT. THE ALADE HOME — NIGHT / MORNING 10

The compound at night. Rain drips from the zinc roof into a bucket.

Ireti sits on the mat, stitching her slipper. Her cracked phone buzzes.

SUPER: ""Dear Ireti Alade, congratulations. You have been selected as personal caretaker to Chief B. Adenuga. Report to Adenuga Crest Tower, 40th floor, 9 a.m. — G. Okafor""

She reads it. Reads it again. Then she SCREAMS. Dayo jumps up from sleep.

DAYO
Armed robbers?!

IRETI
I GOT IT! Dayo, I got the job!

Mama Funmi sits up, and Ireti throws herself into her mother's arms. Dayo dances in his singlet.

MAMA FUNMI
(laughing and crying)
Which job?

IRETI
Caretaker. For Chief Adenuga. The man on TV!

DAYO
(freezing)
The rich man? The sad-eyes man?

MORNING. Ireti stands at the door with a small nylon bag. Mama Funmi lays both hands on her head and prays.

MAMA FUNMI
Where they've failed, you'll succeed. Where they've left, you'll stand. You'll go out with nothing and come back with plenty. In Jesus' name.

IRETI & DAYO
Amen!

DAYO
Sister, if he gives you jet, bring me small.

Ireti walks out of the compound. As soon as she's gone, Mama Funmi coughs into her wrapper and looks down at a spot of blood on the cloth. She folds it over quickly and hides it before Dayo turns around.

FADE TO:

11 INT. ADENUGA CREST TOWER — FEMI'S OFFICE, 40TH FLOOR — DAY 11

The view from the 40th floor: Lagos spread out to the sea, ships on the horizon.

FEMI sits behind a huge glass desk. Ireti stands in front of it, hands folded. He doesn't offer her a seat.

FEMI
I'll be direct. My grandfather has destroyed twelve caretakers. He'll insult you. Throw food at you. Tell you you're poor and stupid. He'll fire you every day. It's a live-in job, six days a week. Morning massage for his legs, fresh air, medication, meals. Can you do it?

IRETI
Yes, sir.

FEMI
Everyone says yes in this office.
(beat)
The salary is one million naira.

IRETI
(stunned)
One million… a month?

FEMI
A week.

Ireti grips the back of the chair. Her lips move silently, calculating.

FEMI
(frowning)
Are you all right?

IRETI
(almost whispering)
Thirty-eight weeks.

FEMI
Sorry?

IRETI
(smiling through sudden tears)
Thirty-eight weeks is less than one year, sir.

FEMI
(confused)
I… don't know what that means.

IRETI
(wiping her eyes fast)
It means thank you, sir.

FEMI
Don't thank me yet.
(He stands and hands her an address card.)
Survive one week first.

Ireti walks out. Femi watches her through the glass wall, then turns to his notes, writes "38 weeks?" and circles it.

FADE TO:

12 INT./EXT. ADENUGA MANSION — DAY 12

Huge black gates open slowly. A long driveway of palm trees leads to the white mansion. Every curtain is closed in the middle of the afternoon.

At the gatehouse, MALLAM AUDU, in a white cap, smiles at Ireti.

MALLAM AUDU
You're the new one?
(He looks at her small nylon bag.)
Sannu, my daughter. Drink water before you enter. You'll need it.

INT. GRAND HALL. Dust sheets over the sofas, a closed piano, a covered easel in the corner. It's gloomy and silent. At the foot of the 22-step staircase hangs the portrait of Mama Abike.

AUNTY RONKE waits with her hands folded, flanked by a HEAD COOK and FIVE COOKS in white.

RONKE
You're welcome. I'm Aunty Ronke. I run this house.
(She smiles with only her mouth.)
I'll be honest with you, because I like honesty. This job is very hard. And I promise you, before the first month ends, you'll be out of this house.

IRETI
(politely)
Then I'll enjoy the month, ma.

One of the young cooks stifles a laugh. Ronke's smile tightens.

RONKE
Your duties. Massage his legs every morning. Take him outside for air. Make sure he eats. And his medication…
(she taps a locked cabinet)
…I handle the medication. You give him only what I give you. Understood?

IRETI
Understood, ma.

INT. CHIEF'S BEDROOM. Ronke knocks and opens the door. The room is dark except for a thin blade of light through the curtains. CHIEF sits in his wheelchair facing a tall wardrobe mirror with his back to the door. His white hair glows faintly.

RONKE
Good afternoon, sir. Your new caretaker is here.

No response. Ireti waits. Ten seconds. Fifteen. Slowly, Chief turns the wheelchair to face her. His face shows nothing.

CHIEF
Oh. The new one.
(He looks at her taped slippers.)
It's only a matter of time before you leave.

IRETI
Why would you say that, sir?

CHIEF
Don't ask me stupid questions.
(He turns back to the mirror.)
Leave my room at once.

Ronke gives Ireti a look: I told you.

In the hallway, Ireti stops at a dusty family photo on the wall: a young Chief laughing with his wife and three small children on a beach. Inside, through the gap in the door, we see Chief pick up a silent phone, check the screen for missed calls, find none, and put it face down.

FADE TO:

13 INT. CHIEF'S BEDROOM — MORNING 13

Morning in the mansion. Cooks move silently through a huge kitchen, and a tray is prepared: fish pepper soup, white bread, tea.

Ireti, now in light-blue scrubs, places the tray in front of Chief.

IRETI
Good morning, sir! Fish pepper soup. The head cook says it's your favourite.

Chief tastes one spoonful. Then he pushes the tray off the table. Soup splashes all over her scrubs. The bowl rolls across the floor.

CHIEF
Too salty. Like everything in this house.

Silence. Ireti looks down at her soaked uniform, then picks up the bowl and smiles.

IRETI
Sir, the soup didn't do anything to you. Next time, throw the bowl at me and spare the soup. That fish is more expensive than my transport for a month.

Chief's eyes flick to her, surprised. He covers it fast.

CHIEF
Are you mocking me?

IRETI
No, sir. I'm mourning the fish.

She kneels and begins cleaning. Then she takes his slippered foot gently to start the massage. He slaps her hand away.

CHIEF
Don't touch me with your poor hands.

IRETI
(quietly, not moving her hand away)
My hands are poor, sir. But they're clean. And they're the only ones in this house that are still here.

Chief stares at her. She begins massaging his legs. He can't feel it, but he watches her do it, his jaw working.

That night in the staff quarters, Ireti scrubs pepper soup out of her uniform in a bucket and calls home on speaker.

MAMA FUNMI (V.O.)
How is the rich man? Is he kind?

IRETI
(looking at her stained uniform, smiling bravely)
He's… very generous, Mummy. He even shared his soup with me.

She laughs. Then she presses the phone to her chest and cries silently.

FADE TO:

14 INT./EXT. CHIEF'S BEDROOM / MANSION GARDEN — DAY 14

The garden, beautiful but overgrown: dry fountains, wild roses, a gazebo covered in vines.

Inside, Ireti pulls the heavy curtain open one inch. Sunlight slices across the room.

CHIEF
(roaring)
CLOSE IT!

IRETI
One inch, sir. One inch of sun a day. Doctor's orders.

CHIEF
Which doctor?

IRETI
Dr. Ireti.

CHIEF
You people from the gutter. You come into rich people's houses, smiling, smiling, and then you steal.

IRETI
(pushing his wheelchair toward the door)
Then let me steal your frown, sir. I promise you won't miss it.

EXT. GARDEN. She wheels him down a ramp into the garden. He grips the armrests, furious. Thunder. It starts to RAIN. She opens a small umbrella over him, and her own back gets soaked.

CHIEF
Look at this! You'll kill me with pneumonia!

IRETI
Sir, do you smell that? Wet earth.
(she breathes deeply)
My mother says it's the smell of the ground saying thank you.

CHIEF
(furious)
You're FIRED.

FEMI, just arriving, runs across the drive with his jacket over his head.

FEMI
Grandpa! What's going on?

CHIEF
Fire her. Today.

FEMI
(looking at a soaked Ireti holding the umbrella over his grandfather, not herself)
Grandpa, she's lasted nine days. Nine. That's a record.

CHIEF
Nine days too many.

Femi looks between them. Something in Chief's eyes isn't anger. It's fear.

FEMI
One more week. Please. For me.

Chief turns his face away. Femi takes that as a yes.

Evening. Ronke comes into Chief's room with the silver tray: water and the small BLUE TABLET. Chief swallows it. Ten minutes later, Ireti watches him slump. His speech slurs, his eyes go glassy and heavy, and he mumbles a name she can't hear. She frowns at the empty glass on the tray.

FADE TO:

15 INT. CHIEF'S STUDY — 3:00 A.M. 15

The mansion at night. A storm. A shout echoes down the dark corridor.

CHIEF (O.S.)
Kehinde! KEHINDE! Don't let go!

Ireti runs barefoot down the corridor and pushes open a door she has never entered: CHIEF'S STUDY. He has fallen asleep in his wheelchair at the desk and is thrashing in a nightmare. She shakes him gently.

IRETI
Sir. Sir! Wake up. It's a dream.

He jerks awake, sweating and confused. For a moment he grips her wrist like a drowning man.

CHIEF
(disoriented)
The fire… the car was burning…

IRETI
You're safe, sir. You're home.

He lets go. On the wall behind him, lit by lightning, is a glass frame holding a torn, faded green shirt. On the collar, in old marker: "KEHINDE". The fabric is burnt at the edges. Ireti steps toward it.

CHIEF
(sharp)
Don't touch that!

IRETI
(stopping)
I'm sorry, sir. Who is Kehinde?

A long silence. Chief looks at the shirt.

CHIEF
A man who put his hands in fire for a stranger.
(beat)
The only person who ever saved me without sending an invoice.

IRETI
(softly smiling)
My father's name was Kehinde, sir.

CHIEF
(dismissive, turning away)
Half of Nigeria is called Kehinde. Go back to sleep.

Ireti closes the door. Chief stares at the burnt shirt in its frame. In the dark corridor, Ireti stops, frowns, and looks down at her own right palm, thinking of her father's scar. Then she shakes her head: impossible.

FADE TO:

16 EXT. GATEHOUSE / INT. CHIEF'S BEDROOM — SUNDAY EVENING **16**

The gatehouse at sunset. A small radio plays Hausa music. Steam rises from two cups of tea.

Ireti sits with MALLAM AUDU on a wooden bench.

IRETI
Mallam, why is he like this? Was he always so… hard?

MALLAM AUDU
(laughing gently)
Hard? Oga used to dance in that garden. He painted pictures. Every Tuesday, young boys came here and he taught them business, free of charge.
(beat)
Then Madam Abike died, twenty-five years ago. He raised the three children alone. Sold his first car to pay Segun's school fees in London. Never married again. Worked until his back bent.

IRETI
And now?

MALLAM AUDU
Now his children are big people. Abuja. Port Harcourt. London. They send wine. They send cakes. They send money to the money's owner.
(He shakes his head.)
Every Sunday, my daughter, Oga wears his blue agbada and sits by the window. Waiting. Ten years. Nobody comes.
(beat)
And every Monday, he insults the caretaker.

Ireti's eyes fill.

IRETI
(almost to herself)
He's not wicked. He's lonely.

MALLAM AUDU
In this house, those two wear the same clothes.

INT. CHIEF'S BEDROOM. Ireti opens the door quietly. Chief sits at the window in a royal-blue agbada and fila,

perfectly dressed, staring down at the empty gate. A dusk-lit silhouette.

CHIEF
(without turning)
What do you want?

IRETI
Nothing, sir.

She doesn't speak. She just pulls a stool up beside his wheelchair and sits, looking down at the empty gate with him.

Minutes pass. The sun sets. Chief doesn't send her away. Close on his hand on the armrest, then hers on the windowsill, an inch apart. Neither moves. Neither speaks. For the first time in ten years of Sundays, he isn't waiting alone.

FADE TO:

17 INT. CHIEF'S BEDROOM / EXT. LAGOS CIVIC HALL — NIGHT 17

Chief's bedroom, the curtains open two inches now. The TV shows grainy 1978 concert footage: COMMANDER KOLA AJALA in a white suit playing a gold guitar, the crowd dancing.

Ireti massages Chief's legs. She notices his fingers on the armrest, tapping in perfect rhythm.

IRETI
(teasing)
Sir. Your fingers are dancing.

CHIEF
(stopping them)
They're not.

IRETI
They are. I saw them. They were doing…
(she imitates a juju shoulder dance)
…this.

CHIEF
(despite himself, a tiny breath of a

laugh)
That's not how you dance juju. You look like a chicken in a generator.
(beat, softer, watching the TV)
1978. I danced to that exact song with Abike, in her father's compound in Ibadan. She stepped on my feet eleven times. I counted.

IRETI
Sir, Commander Ajala is doing his farewell concert. This Saturday. At Civic Hall.

CHIEF
(cold again)
And who will carry a cripple to a concert? You?

IRETI
Yes, sir. Me.

CHIEF
With what money? Those tickets cost more than your father's…

He stops himself. Ireti's smile doesn't move, but her eyes flicker.

EXT. LAGOS CIVIC HALL — SATURDAY NIGHT. Neon lights, a crowd in aso-ebi. Ireti pushes Chief's wheelchair up the ramp. He wears his blue agbada, grumbling.

CHIEF
If anybody I know sees me here…

IRETI
Then they'll see you enjoying yourself, sir. It'll be breaking news.

INT. HALL. Lights, a brass section, a dancing crowd. On stage, the 72-year-old COMMANDER AJALA stops between songs and shades his eyes against the light.

COMMANDER AJALA
(into the mic)
Wait… wait! Is that Chief Babatunde Adenuga in the house?!
(The spotlight swings onto Chief.)
Baba Abike! The man who danced to my first record before I had shoes!
(The crowd cheers.)
This one is for you, Chief. And for Mama Abike in heaven!

The band starts THE song. Chief's chin trembles. Ireti grabs the handles of his wheelchair and gently rocks it side to side to the beat, dancing around it. The crowd joins in. Chief's mouth twitches, then breaks into a smile, the first real one of the film, wide and wet-eyed.

In the car home, Chief holds the concert ticket stub. On the back, the price is printed: ₦150,000 EACH.

CHIEF
(quietly)
You paid for these yourself.

IRETI
(looking out the window)
Yes, sir.

CHIEF
Why?

IRETI
Because you smiled tonight, sir.
(She shrugs.)
At that price, it was cheap.

Chief looks at her for a long moment.

CHIEF
What's your name again?

IRETI
(smiling)
Twenty-three days, sir, and you still don't know my name?

CHIEF
I'm asking now.

IRETI
Ireti.

CHIEF
(turning to the window, very softly)
Ireti. Hope.

Close on the seat between them: his hand slowly moves and rests on top of hers. Neither of them looks down.

FADE TO:

18 INT. MANSION — KITCHEN, MEDICINE CABINET AND PANTRY — NIGHT 18

The kitchen after midnight: one light over the sink, the fridge humming.

Ireti holds Chief's hospital discharge papers and runs her finger down the PRESCRIPTION LIST: "Amlodipine, white, 5mg… Calcium… Vitamin D…" No blue tablet. She looks at the medicine cabinet. It's locked, but the key hangs inside the pantry door on a nail. She opens it. On the shelf is an unlabelled brown bottle full of small BLUE TABLETS. She takes one and slips it into her scrubs pocket.

RONKE (O.S.)
What are you looking for?

Ireti spins around. Ronke stands in the dark doorway in her nightgown.

IRETI
(calm)
Cotton wool, ma. Chief's ear is itching.

RONKE
(stepping closer, staring at the open cabinet)
Cotton wool is in the bathroom. Not in my cabinet.

IRETI
Sorry, ma. I'm still learning the house.

RONKE
(a thin smile)
Learn faster.

Ireti leaves. Ronke locks the cabinet and counts the tablets in the brown bottle with her finger. Her face changes. One is missing.

In the pantry, among sacks of rice, Ronke makes a phone call in a whisper. We see her screen: "LEKAN B."

RONKE
(whispering)
Sir… the new girl is asking questions. About the tablets.
(beat)
Yes, sir. He's smiling now. He went to a concert.
(beat)
No, sir, I won't let it spoil anything before the AGM.
(beat)
Yes, sir. I'll handle her.

She hangs up and looks at the ceiling, toward Chief's room.

FADE TO:

19 INT. CHIEF'S BEDROOM — DAY 19

A medical van in the driveway. Portable scan equipment is wheeled up the ramp.

DR. HASSAN clips new scans onto a lightbox. FEMI is there, sleeves rolled up. Ireti stands by the wall. Chief sits in his wheelchair, arms folded.

DR. HASSAN
The swelling has gone down. And this…
(he points)
…is good news. The nerve isn't severed. It's compressed. Pinched. With decompression surgery on the spine, and then six months of hard rehabilitation…

FEMI
(hardly breathing)
He can walk?

DR. HASSAN
I can't promise. But there's a real chance. Chief, you could walk again.

Femi laughs out loud and hugs Dr. Hassan. Ireti covers her mouth. Everyone turns to Chief.

CHIEF
No.

Silence.

FEMI
…Grandpa?

CHIEF
No surgery.

FEMI
Grandpa, he just said you can walk!

CHIEF
(calm and terrible)
Walk to where, Femi? To the window? To wait for children who don't come?
(beat)
I walked on two good legs for seventy-five years, and they still left me. Legs are not my problem.
(He turns the wheelchair toward the mirror.)
Let me sit. Everyone out.

FEMI
Grandpa, please…

CHIEF
OUT!

In the corridor, Femi punches the wall softly and walks off. Dr. Hassan packs his bag. Ireti stops him at the top of the stairs, glances around, and presses the BLUE TABLET into his palm.

IRETI
(whispering)
Doctor, please. Test this. Quietly. Don't tell anyone in this house. Not even Aunty Ronke.

DR. HASSAN
(looking at the tablet, then at her)
Where did you get this?

IRETI
From his evening tray. Every night. And every night, he gets dizzy.

Dr. Hassan's face goes very serious. He closes his hand around the tablet.

FADE TO:

20 INT. CHIEF'S BEDROOM — NIGHT 20

The moon over the lagoon. One lamp on in the mansion.

Chief sits in the dark facing the mirror. Ireti enters with a cup of tea, sets it down and sits on the floor beside his wheelchair.

CHIEF
If you came to beg me about surgery, save your breath.

IRETI
I didn't come to beg. I came to ask a question.
(beat)
Why don't you want to walk, sir?

A long silence. When he speaks, it's barely above a whisper.

CHIEF
When Abike died, Segun was fourteen. Kunle, ten. Lola, seven. I didn't know how to plait hair. I learned. I didn't know how to cook. I learned. I sold my first car, a Peugeot 504, to pay Segun's school fees in London. I worked

until my back bent like a question mark.

(his voice cracks)

I gave them everything. Houses. Shares. Generational wealth.

(beat)

And now they're "busy." Busy with the life I built for them.

IRETI

(softly)

Sir…

CHIEF

So tell me, Ireti. If my own blood can't love me… why would a girl I pay one million naira a week love me?

(He finally looks at her.)

What's the point of walking, if nobody is walking toward me?

Ireti looks at her hands. Then she decides something.

IRETI

Can I tell you the truth, sir?

(beat)

My mother is dying. She has a growth on her heart. The doctor gave her one year. That was three months ago. The surgery is in India, and it costs thirty-eight million.

(a small, brave smile)

That's why I took this job. For the money. I won't lie to you.

Chief stares at her, stunned.

IRETI

I came for the money, sir.

(beat)

But I stay for you.

CHIEF

(hoarse)

Your mother is dying… and you're here. Washing an old man's feet. Taking pepper soup on your chest.

IRETI
She told me to make the best of the time I have.
(She takes his hand.)
You have more time than her, sir. Please don't waste it sitting in the dark.

Chief's eyes fill. He looks away, at the mirror, at the old man in it.

CHIEF
I'll pay for your mother's surgery. Tomorrow. Tell Femi…

IRETI
(firmly)
No, sir.

CHIEF
No?

IRETI
If you pay, you'll always wonder whether I loved you for money. Like everyone else.
(beat)
I'll earn it. Thirty-eight weeks. Let me earn it.

Chief looks at her as if she's speaking a language he forgot.

CHIEF
(after a long pause)
…Fine. I'll do the surgery.
(beat)
On one condition. When I wake up, yours is the first face I see.

IRETI
(laughing through tears)
Sir, my face in the morning is not for the faint-hearted.

CHIEF
I'll take the risk.

She lays her head against the arm of his wheelchair. Slowly he lifts his hand and rests it on her head, the way a grandfather blesses a child.

Outside the door, in the dark corridor, Aunty Ronke stands with her ear to the wood. She has heard everything. She walks away fast, already dialling.

FADE TO:

21 INT. PRIVATE HOSPITAL — RECOVERY ROOM — DAY 21

The hospital at sunrise. An "OPERATION IN PROGRESS" light switches off.

Chief's eyes flutter open, groggy from the anaesthetic. The first thing in focus is Ireti's face, inches away, with her hair a mess and dark circles under her eyes.

CHIEF
(croaking)
You're ugly in the morning.

IRETI
(grinning)
And you're alive, sir. We're both lucky.

Chief laughs, a real, rusty, painful laugh. He winces and laughs again. At the door, FEMI freezes with two coffees in his hands. He hasn't heard that laugh in ten years.

FEMI
(whispering to himself)
He's laughing.

Femi looks at Ireti, really looks at her, for the first time. In his pocket, the note "38 weeks?" crinkles in his hand.

FADE TO:

22 INT./EXT. ADENUGA MANSION — MONTAGE OVER WEEKS — DAY 22

The mansion from the outside, one curtain at a time sliding open across the façade, until the whole house is glowing with sunlight.

REHAB ROOM. Parallel bars and mats. Chief, sweating, is strapped into a standing frame. A PHYSIOTHERAPIST counts.

Ireti cheers from the side.

PHYSIO
…nine… ten! Good, Chief!

CHIEF
(gasping)
I'll sue you. Both of you.

IRETI
With which legs, sir? Come and catch us first!

GRAND HALL. Ireti pulls the dust sheet off the piano, then off the EASEL in the corner. Underneath is an unfinished painting of the garden, dated 2015.

IRETI
Sir… you paint?

CHIEF
(gruff)
Painted. Past tense.

IRETI
(putting a brush in his hand)
Present continuous, sir. I failed English, but not that one.

GARDEN. Ireti walks up the driveway carrying a fluffy brown PUPPY. Chief recoils.

CHIEF
What is that? Who brought this rat into my house?!

IRETI
He's a gift, sir. From me. He needs a name.

The puppy licks Chief's hand. He fights it, and loses.

CHIEF
(grumbling, stroking it)
…Monday.

IRETI
Monday? Why Monday?

CHIEF
Because Mondays used to be the worst day in this house.
(He scratches the puppy's ears.)
Let's see if he can fix it.

Late afternoon. Chief paints at the easel in the open garden, Monday asleep on his feet. Ireti fixes the dry fountain with Mallam Audu. Water bursts out, and they both get soaked. Chief laughs so hard he nearly drops his brush. Behind a curtain upstairs, Aunty Ronke watches the laughing garden without smiling.

FADE TO:

23 EXT. MANSION — GATE AND GARDEN — TUESDAY MORNING 23

The mansion at sunrise. The front gate is closed and the street outside is quiet.

FLASHBACK, a week earlier. Chief and Ireti watch a TV business show.

CHIEF
(grumbling at the screen)
This boy is talking rubbish. Profit before cash flow?
(beat, wistful)
I used to teach young people for free. Every Tuesday. Two hundred of them in this garden. I miss it.

Close on Ireti's face: an idea.

Back to the present. On Ireti's cracked phone, a flyer she designed: Chief's photo in gold. "TUESDAYS WITH CHIEF: Free business mentoring with Chief Babatunde Adenuga, founder of Adenuga Crest. Banana Island. Tuesday, 10 a.m." She posts it on Chief's dormant official page. Within the hour it's shared 40,000 times.

Tuesday, 9:50 a.m. MALLAM AUDU runs up the driveway, cap in hand.

MALLAM AUDU
Oga! Oga! There are… there are TWO HUNDRED young people at the gate!

CHIEF
(stunned, turning to Ireti)
What did you do?

IRETI
(innocent)
I opened the gate, sir. You do the rest.

EXT. GARDEN. Two hundred young Nigerians sit on the lawn with notebooks: tailors, programmers, food sellers, a girl with a cake business. Chief, in his wheelchair in a bright ankara shirt, holds a microphone. He looks terrified, then he begins.

CHIEF
Rule number one of business.
(He looks across the garden at Ireti.)
Never despise the person who serves your food. One day she might be the one who serves you your life back.

The crowd claps. Ireti looks down, embarrassed. A young man raises his hand.

YOUNG MAN
Sir, what's the biggest mistake you ever made?

CHIEF
(a long pause)
I gave my children everything except my time.
(beat)
And then I was surprised when they gave me everything except theirs.

The garden goes quiet. Then the applause is even louder.

A black car rolls up the drive. LEKAN steps out with flowers and freezes at the sight of two hundred people and Chief laughing with a microphone. He forces a smile.

LEKAN
Chief! Ah! All this excitement… is it good for your heart?

CHIEF
(smiling)
My heart has been bored for ten years, Lekan. Let it work.

Lekan's smile stays. His eyes don't. He looks up at the house, at a curtain where Aunty Ronke is standing.

FADE TO:

24 INT. MANSION — STAFF QUARTERS / EXT. GARDEN — DAY 24

A hot afternoon. Monday the puppy chases a butterfly across the lawn.

Ireti's phone rings: "DR. HASSAN". She steps behind the gazebo.

DR. HASSAN (V.O.)
Ireti. That tablet. It's not for blood pressure. It's a strong sedative, mixed with a drug that crashes blood pressure. Give it to a seventy-five-year-old man every evening, and he'll be dizzy, confused and depressed.
(beat)
And he'll fall.

IRETI
(her hand over her mouth)
The stairs.

DR. HASSAN (V.O.)
Somebody has been putting him to sleep for a long time. Tell Femi. Today.

IRETI
(whispering)
Somebody pushed him down those stairs without ever touching him.

She runs toward the house, but stops dead in the doorway. In the grand hall, Femi, Aunty Ronke and two security men stand around HER nylon bag, which is open on the floor.

FADE TO:

25 INT. MANSION — GRAND HALL — DAY 25

The grand hall, now bright and alive. Then a cold close-up on a velvet jewellery box lying open and empty.

On top of Ireti's faded nylon bag lies a dazzling DIAMOND NECKLACE, the one Mama Abike wears in the portrait above them.

RONKE
(holding it up)
Mama Abike's necklace. From Chief's locked box. In HER bag.

IRETI
(stunned)
That's… I've never seen it before in my life.

RONKE
These gutter girls, sir. I told you from the first day.

FEMI
(cold, hurt)
Ireti. Is this how you planned to get your "thirty-eight weeks"?

IRETI
Sir, please, listen to me. I didn't take it. There's something I must tell you about the medicine. Dr. Hassan just called…

RONKE
(cutting in loudly)
Now she'll start inventing stories about medicine to save herself! Sir, she's been sniffing around my cabinet for weeks!

Femi's phone buzzes: "LEKAN B". He glances at it, stressed.

FEMI
(to security)
The AGM is in two weeks. If the press hears there's a thief in Chief's house…

The lift dings. CHIEF wheels in from the rehab room, sweaty and happy, with Monday on his lap.

CHIEF
What's all this noise? Ireti, I did fifteen today…

He sees the necklace. He sees her open bag. His face drains.

RONKE
(gently, poisonously)
I'm sorry, sir. And I'm sure she told you a sad story about a dying mother too?
(beat)
That's the oldest trick in Lagos.

Chief turns slowly to Ireti. Everything he believed in for months hangs on her face.

CHIEF
(barely)
Is it true?

IRETI
(kneeling beside his wheelchair, tears falling)
Sir. Look at me. You know me. You KNOW me.

Chief looks at her for a long moment. Then, slowly and deliberately, he turns his face away from her to the side, exactly the way he turned it away from Femi in the hospital.

Ireti stops breathing.

FEMI
(quietly)
Leave. Before I call the police.

Ireti stands. She picks up her bag and leaves the necklace on the floor. At the door she turns back once.

IRETI
(to Chief's turned head)
Please take your medicine from someone else tonight, sir. Anybody else.

Her phone rings. "DAYO". She answers, walking out.

DAYO (V.O., SOBBING)
Sister! Sister, Mummy collapsed! They've taken her to the emergency… Sister, she's not waking up!

Ireti drops the bag. She runs down the long driveway barefoot, her slippers left behind. Monday leaps off Chief's lap and chases after her, barking, all the way to the gate. Mallam Audu catches the puppy and watches her go.

In the hall, Ronke picks up the necklace and smiles at the portrait of Mama Abike. Chief sits with his face still turned to the wall. A single tear runs down into his beard.

FADE TO:

26 INT. CHIEF'S BEDROOM — NIGHT 26

The mansion at night, the curtains closed again one by one across the façade. The house is dark once more.

Chief sits facing the mirror. The easel is covered. Monday whines at the door. Ronke enters with the silver tray: water and one BLUE TABLET.

RONKE
Your evening tablet, sir.

Chief picks it up. He looks at it. Ireti's words echo: "Take your medicine from someone else tonight."

A knock. MALLAM AUDU stands in the doorway, cap in his hands. He has never come upstairs in thirty years.

MALLAM AUDU
Oga. Forgive me. I've served you thirty years. I must say what my eyes saw.

RONKE
(sharply)
Mallam, go back to your gate!

MALLAM AUDU
(ignoring her)
At noon today, I saw Madam Ronke go into the staff quarters with a

velvet box. She came out without it.

(beat)

And every Friday for six years, Mr. Lekan's driver gives her a brown envelope through my gate.

Ronke's face freezes. Behind Audu, DR. HASSAN appears, holding a sealed envelope.

DR. HASSAN

Chief. Miss Alade asked me to give you this if anything ever happened to her.

(He hands over a lab report.)

The blue tablet you've been taking every evening is a sedative and a blood-pressure crash drug. Not prescribed. Not by me. Not by anyone.

(beat)

It's why you were dizzy. It's why you fell.

Chief reads the report. His hands shake. Slowly he looks up at Ronke and holds the blue tablet out to her on his flat palm.

CHIEF

(very quietly)

Ronke. Swallow it.

RONKE

Sir…

CHIEF

You've given it to me a thousand times. Swallow one.

Ronke doesn't move. Her hands start to tremble. Then she drops to her knees.

RONKE

(sobbing)

It was Mr. Lekan! He said just keep you weak, keep you sad, until the AGM, so the doctors would sign that you're not fit… He promised me a house, sir, a house in Lekki…

FEMI rushes in, summoned by Audu, just in time to hear it. He goes white.

FEMI
Uncle Lekan…

CHIEF
(cold, calm)
Don't call the police yet. Let Lekan think he's winning.
(beat)
Femi. Where's Ireti?

FEMI
(ashamed)
I threw her out, Grandpa. Her mother collapsed. She ran barefoot.

Chief closes his eyes. When he opens them, there's something there we haven't seen before: fire.

CHIEF
Bring my blue agbada. We're going to Mushin.

FEMI
Grandpa, you haven't left this house without her in months…

CHIEF
Then it's time I went to find her.

Chief throws the blue tablet into the toilet and flushes. Monday barks. Mallam Audu bows his head.

FADE TO:

27 INT. PUBLIC HOSPITAL, IKEJA — FEMALE WARD — NIGHT 27

The public hospital at night: a broken streetlight, a convoy of three black SUVs pulling up in the mud, and onlookers staring.

In the ward, Mama Funmi lies on an oxygen mask, barely conscious. Ireti sits on the floor holding her hand, eyes swollen. Dayo sleeps against the wall.

The ward goes quiet. Every patient turns. FEMI pushes CHIEF ADENUGA's wheelchair down the long aisle between the beds, in his royal-blue agbada.

IRETI
(rising, shocked)
Sir…?

CHIEF
(stopping in front of her)
I turned my face away from you. The same way I turned it away from my own grandson.
(His voice breaks.)
Forgive a stupid old man.

IRETI
(crying)
Sir, you're here. In this place.

CHIEF
You came to my dark house. I can come to yours.

Mama Funmi stirs. She pulls her oxygen mask down weakly and squints at the man in the wheelchair.

MAMA FUNMI
(faint)
Chief… Adenuga? From the TV?

CHIEF
Madam. Your daughter saved my life.

MAMA FUNMI
(a faint smile)
Her father was like that too. Always saving people.
(She coughs.)
He once pulled a rich man out of a burning car. On the Ibadan expressway. Night. A black Mercedes, upside down…

Chief goes completely still.

MAMA FUNMI
…he wrapped the man's bleeding arm with his own shirt. When the ambulance came, he ran, because

his danfo owner would sack him if he came back late.
(She smiles.)
He came home with no shirt and burnt hands. Laughing. He said the rich man kept shouting, "What's your name? What's your name?"

CHIEF
(barely a whisper)
…And he said, "Kehinde."

Mama Funmi stares at him. Ireti's hand flies to her mouth.

CHIEF
(shaking)
2010. September. I was fifty-nine.
(He holds up his right arm and pulls back the agbada sleeve: an old jagged scar.)
For sixteen years I put his name in every newspaper in Nigeria. "KEHINDE, WHO SAVED ME ON THE EXPRESSWAY, PLEASE COME FORWARD." Nobody came.

MAMA FUNMI
(tears rolling)
He couldn't read, sir.

Silence in the whole ward. Ireti pulls out her phone and shows Chief a photo: her father smiling, his right palm out, the burn scar across it.

Chief takes the phone in both hands and weeps openly. Then he reaches out and takes Ireti's hands.

CHIEF
Your father pulled me out of the fire. Then I lost my legs and my heart, and you pulled me out again.
(beat)
Two Alades. Twice.

IRETI
(sobbing)
Sir…

CHIEF
(firmly, to Femi)
Her mother goes to India this week.

IRETI
Sir, no. I told you, I want to earn it…

CHIEF
You did earn it.
(He squeezes her hands.)
Sixteen years ago, your father paid in advance.

Ireti collapses into his lap, crying. Dayo, awake now, stares open-mouthed.

FEMI
(quietly, already on the phone)
Air ambulance to Chennai. Thursday. Best surgeon. Whatever it costs.

Mama Funmi pulls Ireti close and whispers.

MAMA FUNMI
Don't come to India. Dayo will come with me.
(She looks at Chief.)
Go and finish what you started. Your father never left a fire half-done.

FADE TO:

28 INT. SEGUN ADENUGA'S OFFICE, ABUJA — DAY 28

Abuja from the air: wide roads, Aso Rock in the distance, a sleek glass office tower.

Ireti, in her one good dress, sits across from SEGUN ADENUGA. On a big screen on the wall, on video, are KUNLE (Port Harcourt) and LOLA (London). Femi set up the meeting. He stands by the window.

SEGUN
(checking his watch)
Femi said this was urgent. You're Daddy's caretaker? Is he okay?

IRETI
He's not okay, sir. He hasn't been okay for ten years.

KUNLE (ON SCREEN)
Daddy's fine. He's just… old. He's grumpy. He pushes everyone away.

IRETI
With respect, sir, he pushes you away first, so you won't be the one who leaves.
(beat)
Every Sunday for ten years he wears his blue agbada and sits at the window, watching the gate. Waiting for you.

Silence. Lola's hand goes to her mouth.

LOLA (ON SCREEN)
(quietly)
Every Sunday?

IRETI
Every Sunday, ma. And every Sunday, nobody comes. On his seventy-fifth birthday, he waited with a cake and one candle. Then Mr. Segun called for one minute and twelve seconds.
(beat)
That night, he fell down twenty-two steps.

Segun slowly sits back. He looks at Femi. Femi nods.

SEGUN
(hoarse)
We thought… we thought he was just old.

IRETI
He's not old, sir. He's waiting.

SEGUN
(his voice cracking)
…Oh.

IRETI
And there's one more thing. Mr. Lekan has been drugging your father to keep him weak until next Thursday's AGM. He wants to declare him unfit and take control of his shares.

KUNLE (ON SCREEN)
(sitting up)
Lekan? Wait. Lekan sent us proxy forms last month. He said it was routine paperwork, for while Daddy recovers…

LOLA (ON SCREEN)
I signed it. I didn't even read it.

SEGUN
(closing his eyes)
We all signed it.

Femi turns from the window.

FEMI
Then sign the revocation. Tonight. Gabriel has the papers.

SEGUN
(standing)
We'll sign.
(to Ireti)
And… don't tell Daddy. Let us come ourselves.
(beat)
For once, let us be the ones walking toward him.

Ireti walks out of the tower into the Abuja sun. Femi follows.

FEMI
You took a night bus to Abuja. With your own money. For a family that's not yours.

IRETI
(smiling)
He's a grandfather, sir. Every family needs one.

Femi looks at her as if seeing the whole story for the first time.

FADE TO:

29 INT. MANSION — REHAB ROOM — NIGHT (THREE DAYS BEFORE THE AGM) 29

The mansion at night, every light in the house on. Rain on the glass of the rehab room.

Parallel bars. DR. HASSAN and the PHYSIO stand ready. Chief grips the bars, sweat pouring down his face. Ireti stands at the far end of the bars, ten steps away, arms open.

PHYSIO
No frame tonight, Chief. Just you.

CHIEF
(through gritted teeth)
If I fall, I'm firing all of you.

IRETI
If you fall, sir, I'm the one you'll fall on. Come.

He pushes up. His legs shake violently. He STANDS, fully upright for the first time in the film, trembling. Monday barks wildly.

IRETI
(whispering)
One step, sir. Only one.

His right foot slides forward an inch, then a full step. Then the left. Dr. Hassan grips the physio's arm. Three. Four. Chief is crying. Five. Six. His knees buckle on seven. He lunges, and falls forward into Ireti's arms. She holds him up, both of them laughing and sobbing.

CHIEF
(gasping)
Seven.

IRETI
Seven steps!

CHIEF
Don't tell Femi.

IRETI
(pulling back)
Sir?!

CHIEF
(a wicked glint in his eye)
Let him see it at the AGM. Let Lekan see it.
(beat)
I'm a billionaire, Ireti. I'm allowed one drama.

Ireti's phone buzzes: a video call from "DAYO — INDIA". She answers. Dayo is in a Chennai hospital corridor, crying with joy.

DAYO (ON SCREEN)
Sister! Mummy is awake! The surgery was successful! The doctor said she'll live! She'll LIVE!

Ireti collapses onto the mat, sobbing. Chief, still holding the bars, takes two more wobbly steps toward her phone, just to see Dayo's face. Nine steps.

FADE TO:

30 INT. ADENUGA CREST TOWER — BOARDROOM, 40TH FLOOR — DAY 30

The gold tower in morning sun. Reporters with cameras gather outside the lobby. A sign reads "ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING — SHAREHOLDERS ONLY".

A long boardroom table. Twelve BOARD MEMBERS. FEMI sits at one end, tense. LEKAN stands at the head in his black agbada, holding a remote. A screen behind him shows a photo of Chief slumped in his wheelchair.

LEKAN
Ladies and gentlemen, it breaks my heart. Our founder, Chief

Babatunde Adenuga, is permanently incapacitated.

(He clicks: a medical report.)

Signed by an independent doctor: paralysed, depressed, mentally unstable. He smashes phones. He fires caretakers. He took a waitress to a concert.

(sad smile)

He is not the man we knew.

FEMI

(standing)

That doctor never examined him!

LEKAN

Sit down, Femi.

(He holds up three forms.)

His own children, Segun, Kunle and Lola, have given me their proxy votes. With them, I move that Chief's fifty-one percent be placed in a board trust under the Vice-Chairman's control.

(beat)

And that the board votes no confidence in our young CEO.

Murmurs around the table. A few hands begin to rise. Femi grips the table.

FEMI

My grandfather isn't here today because…

LEKAN

(gently, almost kindly)

Because he can't walk, Femi. He'll never walk again. Even Dr. Hassan said so. Let the old man rest. All in favour…

TAP.

Everyone turns to the double doors.

TAP.

The ivory tip of a cane on marble.

TAP.

The doors swing open. CHIEF BABATUNDE ADENUGA stands in the doorway in a cream agbada, leaning on his ivory cane, his arm through Ireti's. Behind them stand Gabriel, Dr. Hassan, two POLICE OFFICERS, and Aunty Ronke in handcuffs.

The room stops breathing.

Chief gently takes his arm out of Ireti's. She nods. ALONE, step by slow step, he walks the length of the boardroom. Every board member's head turns with him. Lekan's raised hand drops.

Femi rises slowly from his chair. His mouth opens, but nothing comes out. His eyes fill. He tries to speak and can't. He is completely speechless.

FEMI
(finally, a whisper)
…Grandpa.

Chief reaches the head of the table, stops beside Lekan and rests both hands on his cane.

CHIEF
Lekan. You were saying something… about my legs?

LEKAN
(white, stammering)
Chief… Chief, God is great, this is a miracle! I was only…

CHIEF
You were only putting me to sleep. Every evening. For six years.
(He nods to Gabriel.)

GABRIEL
(laying papers on the table)
Proxy revocations, signed last night by Segun, Kunle and Lola Adenuga.
(beat)
And this…
(He plays a phone recording.)

RONKE (RECORDING)
"It was Mr. Lekan! He said keep you weak, keep you sad, until the AGM…"

DR. HASSAN
And the lab report on the tablets. The police have a copy.

Lekan looks around the table for an ally. No one meets his eyes.

LEKAN
(desperate)
Chief, twenty years! Twenty years I stood by you!

CHIEF
Twenty years you stood by me, Lekan. Waiting for me to fall.
(beat)
And when I fell, a waitress picked me up.

The officers step forward. Lekan is led out past the window, past the reporters' cameras flashing in the lobby below.

Chief turns to the board.

CHIEF
I have a motion. Femi Adenuga remains CEO.
(beat)
And Babatunde Adenuga remains alive. All in favour?

Every hand at the table goes up. Then the board members start applauding, standing one by one.

Femi walks around the table and hugs his grandfather hard, like a little boy. Chief holds him and pats his back.

FEMI
(crying into his shoulder)
You walked. You WALKED.

CHIEF
(looking over Femi's shoulder at Ireti, standing by the door)
No, my son. She walked me.

FADE TO:

31 INT. ADENUGA MANSION — CHIEF'S BEDROOM / DINING HALL — SUNDAY EVENING 31

The mansion at golden hour. Every curtain is open, the fountain is flowing, and Monday is chasing his tail on the lawn.

Chief stands at his bedroom window, standing, with his cane, in his royal-blue agbada. He's watching the gate, the way he has every Sunday for ten years. Ireti brings him tea.

IRETI
Sir, you don't have to wait at the window anymore. You have Tuesdays now. You have Monday.
(the puppy barks)
You have me.

CHIEF
(smiling sadly)
Habit, my daughter. Ten years of habit.

Down at the gate, a horn. Then another. And a third. Three black cars roll up the driveway.

Chief squints. His teacup starts to shake.

The car doors open. SEGUN steps out with his twin twelve-year-olds. Then KUNLE with his wife and two sons. Then LOLA, just off a flight from London, with her husband and baby daughter. Eleven people stand in the driveway, looking up at his window.

Lola waves. The twins shout, "GRANDPA!"

CHIEF
(his voice gone)
Ireti…

IRETI
(tears streaming, grinning)
I didn't tell them anything, sir.
(beat)
They came by themselves.

Chief turns from the window and walks, unsteady but fast with his cane, out of the room and to the top of the GRAND STAIRCASE, the same 22 steps. He stops at the top and looks down. His children are rushing into the hall below.

SEGUN
(looking up, voice breaking)
Daddy. We're sorry. We thought you were just old.
(beat)
We didn't know you were waiting.

Chief holds the banister, and step by step, with Ireti one step behind him, he walks DOWN the staircase that broke him, all 22 steps. At the bottom, beneath Mama Abike's portrait, his children and grandchildren surround him in one big crying embrace.

INT. DINING HALL. The long table is full for the first time in ten years: candles, jollof, pounded yam, laughter, grandchildren arguing. Ireti, in her blue

scrubs, quietly serves the food with the cooks and keeps to the edge.

CHIEF
(tapping his glass)
Ireti. Come and sit.

IRETI
(smiling, shaking her head)
Sir, this is family.

CHIEF
Exactly.
(He pulls out the empty chair at his right hand.)
Sit.

The whole table goes quiet. Segun looks at the chair.

SEGUN
(softly)
Daddy, that was Mummy's chair. Nobody has sat there in twenty-five years.

CHIEF
(looking at Ireti)
I know.

Ireti slowly sits. One of the twins leans over.

TWIN
Grandpa, who is she?

CHIEF
(without hesitation)
Your aunty. My granddaughter.
(beat)
The one who found the way home for all of you.

Lola reaches across the table and squeezes Ireti's hand. Segun raises his glass to her. The table erupts in laughter at something one of the children says. Chief sits back and looks at all of them, his family, full and noisy. He closes his eyes and smiles like a man who finally has something to live for.

FADE TO:

32 EXT. NEW HOUSE, LEKKI / EXT. MANSION GARDEN — MONTHS LATER — DAY **32**

A beautiful new white bungalow with a red-tiled roof and a garden, a ribbon tied across the gate.

A black car pulls up. MAMA FUNMI steps out, healthy now, glowing in a cream lace iro and buba, with DAYO beside her in a brand-new university T-shirt. Chief stands at the gate with his cane and holds out a set of keys.

CHIEF
Madam. Your new house.

MAMA FUNMI
(shaking her head, crying)
Chief, it's too much…

CHIEF
It's not a gift. It's a debt.
(He pulls out Ireti's old savings notebook, "₦9,000,000 of ₦38,000,000", and under her handwriting writes, in big letters:)
"PAID IN FULL — SEPTEMBER 2010."
Mama Funmi laughs through her tears and hugs him.

DAYO
(holding up an admission letter)
Sister! Full scholarship! The Kehinde Alade Foundation!

IRETI
(turning to Chief)
The what foundation?

CHIEF
(innocently)
I don't know. Ask Femi.
Femi, leaning on the car, holds up both hands: not me.

MONTAGE, final:

IRETI in a crisp white nursing-school uniform walks through a university gate, books in her arms. Chief and Femi wave from the car like proud parents.

TUESDAY. Three hundred young people in the mansion garden. Chief STANDS at the microphone with no cane, Monday at his feet.

The GRAND HALL. Beside Mama Abike's portrait now hangs a NEW painting by Chief: a young woman in light-blue scrubs, opening a curtain, sunlight pouring in. The title card under it reads "IRETI".

EXT. GARDEN. SUNSET. Chief and Ireti sit side by side on the edge of the fountain, sharing tea.

IRETI
Sir. Can I ask you a stupid question?

CHIEF
(smiling)
You've earned one.

IRETI
What did you learn? From all of this?

CHIEF
(after a long moment, watching the sun)
I thought hope was a feeling. Something you wait for at a window.
(He turns to her.)
It's not. Hope is a person.
(beat)
A person who refuses to leave.

She leans her head on his shoulder. He puts his arm around her.

Slow, high crane shot pulling back: the two of them on the fountain, Monday running circles on the lawn, every window of the mansion open and glowing gold, then the lagoon and Lagos at sunset.

SUPER: "You may be sitting in the darkest room of your life. / Open one inch of curtain. / Hope only needs one inch."

SUPER: "A POOR GIRL HELPED A BILLIONAIRE CEO GRANDPA WALK AGAIN"

SUPER: "Written by [WRITER'S NAME]"

FADE OUT.